



PROTECTION CLUSTER National Meeting – Minutes

Location: Kyiv, Ukraine (WebEx meeting)

Date: 13 March 2024

Participants: CO STABILIZATION SUPPORT SERVICES, NGO "The Tenth of April", ROKADA, BOSCC, HIAS Ukraine, TAF, PeReHID initiative, World Food Programme, ГО "АЛЬЯНС.ГЛОБАЛ", Caritas Ukraine, NGO "Enlightening Initiative", HelpAge, UNHCR, World Vision International, NRC, AVSI Foundation, REACH/IMPACT Initiatives, USAID, IRC, Triangle Generation Humanitaire, Terre des hommes in Ukraine, Helping to Leave, Starenki Charitable Foundation, NGO "LAMPА", Mercy Corps, People in Need, CUAMM, UNICEF, EDF, OTP, UNFPA, Independent/Key Aid/UNHCR, Bibliothèques Sans Frontières, NGO UDA, Danish Refugee Council, Impact Initiatives, INTERSOS, ACAPS, CESVI, Non-governmental organization "Spring of Hope", People In Need Slovak Republic, REACH, NGO Platform, Center for Civilians in Conflict (CIVIC), UNDP, European Union Advisory Mission to Ukraine, Association HelpUAPT, ADRA Ukraine, Right to Protection, Humanity&Inclusion, IOM / PeReHID Initiative, ADTWG, JERU, PO ZDOROVĚ HUMANITARIAN MISSION, Nonviolent Peaceforce, IOM, Medical Teams International, Dorcas, ChildFund Deutschland, OCHA, Council of Europe Office in Ukraine, Peace Winds Japan, Plan International, Polish Humanitarian Action in Ukraine, Depaul Ukraine, NGO CrimeaSOS, БО Мальтійська служба допомоги, PosmishkaUA, WFP, Proliska, FSLC, War Child Alliance, Help - Hilfe zur Selbsthilfe, БО Пліч -о- Пліч, British Red Cross, Medair, People in Peril, Mondo, ICF "Friends' Hands", CF EAST SOS, Охфат, ГО Бюро гендерних стратегій і бюджетування, Стрийська міська асоціація людей з інвалідністю, Чернігів Європейський, Чугуївська правозахисна група, Première Urgence Internationale, NEEKA, ГО "ЦЕНТР ІНТЕГРАЦІЇ"

Agenda item	Summary of discussions	Action Points
1. Strategic updates from Protection Cluster Hub Coordinators	Dnipro Hub (Dnipropetrovska, Kharkivska, Poltavska, Donetska, Luhanska, Zaporizka, Khersonska, Cherkaska, Kirovohradska oblasts) - Increased number of areas under evacuation, yet there was no significant increase in the number of individuals arriving from affected areas. - Partners report concerns that changes in IDP allowance may lead to increased requests for humanitarian assistance and returns, which need to be closely monitored. - Despite the increase in insecurity, there is the expectation of a higher number of returns to some of the most affected oblasts in the east – end of winter. - Some authorities have requested humanitarian assistance not to be provided in areas under mandatory evacuations Vinnytsia Hub (Vinnytska, Khmelnytska, Zhytomyrska, Odeska, Mykolayivska and Chernivetska oblasts): - Security situation: Odesa region was subject to massive shelling at night. On March 2, 18 apartments were destroyed and 12 people were killed. Partners provided PSS, legal and cash assistance. - Partners report increase in the number of IDPs arriving by evacuation train from Donetska oblast to Berdychev in Zhytomyr region. Most people remain in the region and need accommodation in collective sites, which are inaccessible to people with disabilities arriving on each train.	Protection Cluster Partners are encouraged to step up in distribution of information about evacuation process and services available in destination areas, in addition to ongoing emergency response, also engaging with other Clusters Partners are requested to monitor implications of changes in IDP allowances from protection angle in an evidenced-based manner (e.g. possibility of increased returns to unsafe areas; increase of movements to the CSs) Zhytomyrska oblast: protection Cluster partners are encouraged to document

	• In Odesa situation with extension of IDP housing allowance is difficult with long queues, registration by phone, lack of information about scheduling appointments on the DoSP websites. This may result in IDPs eligible for extension of assistance in March not being able to submit their applications on time. • In Chernivtsi there are difficulties with relocation of IDPs from collective sites not included in the Register under the 930 Resolution. People do not want to leave Chernivtsi and move to other hromadas, even when living conditions in the proposed sites are better. Information sessions are provided by the partners. Kyiv Hub (Kyiv, Kyivska oblast, Chernihivska, Cherkaska, Sumska oblasts) • The security situation in the along-the-border hromadas of Sumska and Chernihivska Oblasts remains unsafe with civilian casualties, damages to civilian infrastructure and houses in both oblasts. Evacuations from 5 km zone are ongoing in Sumska oblast. Access restrictions have been announced to 5 km zone • Public transportation: lack of public transportation to reach social services, psychological support sessions, receive humanitarian assistance in border hromadas in Sumy and Chernihiv oblasts; transportation to medical facilities was reported as a key challenge for people with disability in Kyivska, Sumska, Chernihivska oblasts • Interrupted education is reported due to increased attacks, lack of internet access, lack of bomb-shelters, frequent power cuts; mobilization of male teachers • Acute need for psychological assistance to children; community-based activities for adolescents are recommended Lviv Hub (Lvivska, Ternopilska, Volynska and Rivnenska oblasts): • Lack of specialized services and adequate living conditions for elderly IDPs and people with disabilities is a significant problem for the western regions. • 13 hromadas in Lvivska oblast are ready to create the new social service as centers of supported living. • Due to the necessity of re-registration of documents for the continuation of IDP allowance, the burden on responsible bodies has increased significantly, which creates significant queues. • In Lviv, the Sub-National Protection Cluster organized a legal aid information event in a modular town where almost 1,000 IDPs live. Legal teams from R2P, DRC, TGH, and NRC conducted sessions on HLP issues and IDP allowances. Uzhhorod Hub (Zakarpattia and Ivano-Frankivsk) • Solving housing issues continues to play a significant role in the processes of integration of IDPs in host communities.	protection issues related to evacuations Protection Cluster Kyiv Hub will provide updates on Krasnopillya corridor during the next NPC (screening activities vs humanitarian activities to ensure proper separation of security procedures and humanitarian assistance) in April 2024
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	• At the same time, partners from the side of local authorities support the direction of initiatives to create social and temporary housing. Interventions regarding the allocation of cash for rental housing are seen as less acceptable. • - The need for further development of the system of social services is also a prioritized direction for the sphere of protection for the Uzhgorod hub. One of the directions may be to strengthen the capacity of the already existing system of social service centers and social work specialists. • According to the partners, the spheres of protection and education of children need more attention when planning possible interventions and preparation for the next school year. This is related to issues of violence against and among children, as well as enrollment in local educational institutions. • Until now, a large part of IDP children continue to study online, which often leaves them out of the attention of external specialists and relevant services. Age and Disability Technical Working Group presented on challenges in adaptation of older people and people with disabilities, access to accommodation in geriatric facilities and alternative forms of care for them. (<i>presentation attached</i>). The main criteria for assessing the condition and social capacity of the older people and people with disabilities (for non-professionals in the social sphere): Types of activities the person is able to perform: ➢ The main types of simple actions (independent eating, shower, put on clothes) ➢ The main types of complex actions (cooking, cleaning) ➢ Movement (mobility; distance) ➢ Use of transport (including staircase in the public transport) ➢ Making purchases or receiving services (medical services) Degree of impairment ➢ Performs independently ➢ Slight dependence on outside help ➢ Moderate dependence on outside help ➢ Severe dependence on outside help and care The following recommendations are provided: ➢ It is in the best interest of the beneficiary to be provided care at home and in the community whenever possible ➢ Geriatric care is limited (only when there are no other options or other approaches may endanger the beneficiary) ➢ Support and training of social workers in communities ➢ Case management approach ➢ Peer-to-peer principle (engagement of older people to help older people) ➢ Support and capacity building of local NGOs ➢ Support, psychosocial assistance and training for relatives/caregivers caring for older family members or people with disabilities	Partners are encouraged to assess whether external care is needed in every individual case to make an informed decision on whether accommodation in geriatric facility is actually needed. If determined that no alternatives to a geriatric center are feasible, refer to R2P leaflet on legal consideration for placing older people in geriatric care. Age and Disability TWG to organize a dedicated meeting on accommodation and access to specialized services for older people and people with disabilities in areas of displacement, engaging both partners facilitating evacuation and partners providing services in reception areas.
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	R2P developed a leaflet on legislative norms regarding accommodation in geriatric facilities (<i>attached in Ukrainian</i>).	
2. Intentions Survey of Ukrainian Refugees and IDPs - Lives on hold #5 - presentation by UNHCR	UNHCR presented results of the periodic Intention Survey (<i>presentation attached</i>). In addition to IDPs, the survey also includes interviews of refugee returnees. ✓ Return intentions differ according to several factors, in particular: proximity of host countries (for refugees); situation in places of origin (e.g. relatives and/or property), demographic characteristics / vulnerabilities (in particular dependency ratio) and prospects for socio-economic inclusion in host countries or displacement areas (e.g. participation in labour market). ✓ Refugees are more likely to be planning or hoping to return among those originally from Chernihivska, Khersonska or Sumska (more than 76 per cent in each), in contrast to those from Poltavska, Zakarpatska or Kyiv city (60 per cent or less in each). ✓ In the case of IDPs, they are more likely to be planning or hoping to return among those originally from Khersonska, Mykolaivska, Kharkivska, Zaporizka or Dnipropetrovsk (more than 77 per cent in each), in contrast to those from Luhanska, Kyivska or Kyiv city (67 per cent or less in each) ✓ Among those whose previous plans to return permanently did not materialize, the vast majority (81% for refugees and 76% for IDPs) indicated that the deterioration of the security situation in Ukraine and/or their place of origin was the main reason for not having returned as planned. Other reasons reported were concerns about economic opportunities, access to work, reunion with relatives and legal status and because their property had been damaged or was inaccessible. ✓ While visiting relatives continues to be the main reason for refugees' short-term visits, access to healthcare is reported as the second-most frequent motivation, followed by accessing work or taking care of business on a temporary basis and to obtain documentation. ✓ Among IDPs, the main reason for short-term visits is to check or repair their property, followed by visiting relatives and for getting personal supplies. ✓ The majority of refugee returnees returned between May to September 2022, coinciding with the Government of Ukraine's retaking of control of territories in northern oblasts. Close to three quarters of returns took place toward western, northern and eastern oblasts. Around a quarter had visited Ukraine at least once before returning, although this proportion rose to 43% for those that returned after 2022. ✓ More than a quarter of households surveyed had returned to a different place than the one they were living in before the start of the war, although they were highly concentrated among those who were originally from the east (60 per cent of all those originating from this region) and the south (34 per cent), with less than 10 per cent among those from other regions. ✓ Refugee returnees are more likely to be households with dependents (children and/or older persons) compared to refugee households (82 vs. 71%), although those returning to Kyiv city are in higher proportion adult(s) without dependents compared to the average for all refugee returnees (28 vs. 18%). ✓ The main reasons for return coincide with those reported by refugees who are currently planning to return: the desire to be back in their cultural environment and to reunite with relatives. Around a third reported reasons related to access to services in areas of return (education and	Document - Lives on hold: Intentions and Perspectives of Refugees, Refugee Returnees and IDPs from Ukraine #5 Summary Findings (unhcr.org)

	health services) and around a fifth reported challenges in accessing services, work or difficulties to adapt in host countries. ✓ The vast majority of refugees who returned to their place of origin were able to go back to their previous property or dwelling (92%). Among those who returned to a different place, 27% report their dwelling was significantly damaged and 13% were uncertain about its status. ✓ Around a third of refugee returnees report feeling safe in their current locations, although with a higher proportion among those who returned to a different place compared to those who returned to their place of origin (47 vs. 33%). Perceptions of safety were also higher among those residing in western or central oblasts (close to 50%) and lower among those residing in the east (24%). ✓ Compared to their expectations before returning, a significant proportion of refugee returnees report that economic opportunities are worse than they thought they would be (55%), with higher incidence among those currently residing in the south and east of the country. ✓ Only 27% of refugee returnees reported being able to cover all or most of their basic needs, although this was the case for almost half of refugee returnees currently residing in Kyiv city. The most frequent reasons reported by refugees for travelling back to Ukraine are to visit relatives or friends, followed by access to healthcare and to obtain documentation. The presentation also includes information on evolution of cross-border movements, including pendular movements. ✓ 32% of refugees were unable to visit Ukraine even if they wanted to, due to security concerns or lack of funds, followed by caregiving responsibilities, a lack of documentation and the fear of losing their legal status in host countries. ✓ Refugee returnees report that economic opportunities in areas of return are worse than what they expected before returning, and while half of respondents are currently working, only around a quarter reported being able to cover all or most of their basic needs, and only around a third report feeling safe in their current locations.	Population movements can be also viewed at UNHCR's Population Movement Factsheet #1 In case of questions, kindly contact Ms. Karen Whiting, Assistant Representative - Protection, UNHCR whiting@unhcr.org
3. Presentation of the PeReHID Initiative – transition of humanitarian assistance to social protection schemes	The PeReHID Initiative is a technical assistance collaboration between international donors, UN agencies, civil society, and the Government of Ukraine (<i>presentation attached</i>). Objectives: 1. Pave the way for the transition and partial absorption of humanitarian caseloads into a more shock-responsive social protection system 2. Bolster national systems and support the government's agenda to reform the social protection system to make it more inclusive, adaptive and shock- responsive The stages of PeReHID Initiative have been explained and discussed during the meeting and for protection actors PeReHID in practice means: • Supporting and monitoring the transition of cases to the state social protection system. • Foster discussion on how protection activities can bridge the lead times before social protection programmes start. • Design protection programmes through a social protection lens.	PeReHID will be gathering recommendations from the partners on the ground on the needs that State Social Services should provide in the long run; best and worst practices, formulate the advice to the State Social Services on response that should be enacted in emergency situations; input on social service infrastructure, social services international terminology, innovative means of financing

	Understanding vulnerabilities and triggers is important in transition process to be effective. It was noted that IDP allowance is the largest shock response, followed by disability benefits for people affected by explosive devices and damaged housing compensation benefit. Advocacy by the Protection partners and PeReHID is ongoing with the Ministry of the Social Policy regarding vulnerable categories and eligibility for the shock-responsive social protection system. The reform is upcoming in relation to the means testing on IDP allowance but also on other universal benefits. In relation to budgetary capacity to absorb social protection cases, the ability of the Government to continue funding the system. PeReHID is also launching Technical Task Teams of likeminded partners and key Clusters (Cash Working Group, Protection Cluster and Shelter Cluster at the moment) to develop Operational Guidelines on the complementary systems in the three major areas – Forced Displacement, Disability due to Explosive Objects, Identified Protection Needs. In relation to depleted capacity in the social protection services, the capacity is segregated into provision of social benefits (sending the transfers; assessed capacity is sufficient) and social care services where the greater concern is around provision of social care services in the transitional period. ACAPS is producing an analysis report on vulnerabilities with a focus of protection dimension. The report will cover two steps: main protection risks all over Ukraine on macro regions and identify and map vulnerabilities and markers of vulnerabilities in protection dimensions. The analysis will be published at the beginning of April.	PeReHID and protection partners will continue advocacy efforts with multi-stakeholders raising concerns regarding social protection system to provide policy advice to the Government; in the coming months PeReHID is going to release a number of research analyses and recommendations to enrich advocacy efforts to address the gaps in provision of social services The launch of PeReHID Forum is upcoming to discuss and align the social protection system in inter-sectoral levels
4. AOB	Protection Cluster: Discussion on Humanitarian Needs and Response Plan for 2025 is upcoming in the midyear, hence better understanding and more clarity on development vs humanitarian interventions is needed to have harmonized approach on provision of assistance. Due to lack of time, the 2023 Achievements of the National Protection Cluster and AoRs could not be presented in this meeting and will be circulated with NPC mailing list, while the key points and conclusions will be presented in April NPC meeting. Protection Cluster: Advocacy efforts have been made with the Ministry of Social Policy to expand the list of vulnerable categories to Resolution #332. As cuts on extension of IDP allowance may result in returns to unsafe areas, the importance of monitoring, recording, and reporting of the situation (documented cases) in relation to the revisions in IDP allowance have been reiterated by the Protection Cluster. Protection Cluster partners are encouraged to share evidence-based information on implementation of the Resolution, including recording of rejected cases (or even quotes from people) on the applications for extensions of IDP allowance that have been rejected with Protection Cluster Hub Coordinators. The NGO Platform (a membership group of 92 NGOs) is working on a high-level advocacy ahead of the Senior Officials Meeting of EU member states and other key donor states in April 2024 and also seeks for	Protection Cluster will present key conclusions from NPC Achievements for 2023 during the next NPC meeting in April 2024. Accurate data will assist in transition from blanket to targeted assistance, hence Protection Cluster partners are encouraged to share the evidence with Protection Cluster and relevant Hub Coordinators for analysis of the impact of implementation of Resolution #332; Protection Cluster Partners are encouraged to expand awareness raising information sessions with the population using existing materials and posted developed by the Ministry of Social

	evidence of implementation of the Resolution #332 (advocacy@ngoplatformua.org). Protection Cluster will continue providing updates on IDP allowances in the upcoming National Protection Cluster meetings. ADTWG meeting is scheduled for 22 March 2023. Protection Cluster announced discontinuation of Uzhhorod Protection Cluster Hub at the end of March 2024, with Lviv Protection Cluster Hub absorbing Zakarpatska and Ivano-Frankivska oblasts for further coordination.	Policy, and step up counseling and legal assistance to IDPs re-applying for IDP allowance or whose applications were rejected. ADTWG Mailing List Subscription Form Protection Cluster Lviv Hub Coordinator Pavlo Kutana (kutana@unhcr.org) will be in touch with partners on coordination activities in Zakarpatska and Ivano-Frankivska oblasts as of April 2024.
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22 March 2024

Protection Cluster Team